

DIGITALAIKART ORIGINAL

THE IELTS 2026-27

Preparation Handbook

The complete Indian-edition guide to the test — every 2026 fee and booking rule verified from IDP IELTS India, the band scale decoded with real averaging examples, skill-by-skill strategy for Listening, Reading, Writing and Speaking, the One Skill Retake playbook, and the 8-week plan that takes you from diagnostic to test day.

RS. 19,000 THE 2026 FEE AT STAKE	4 SKILLS, ONE SITTING	8 WEEK PREPARATION PLAN	0-9 THE BAND SCALE DECODED
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SECTION 01

Welcome: The Test, the Money and the Plan

You are about to spend Rs. 19,000 on a single morning of English. That is the 2026 IELTS fee in India, and it is exactly why this handbook exists: the test itself is fair and coachable, but the information around it is scattered across coaching advertisements, outdated blogs and contradictory YouTube advice — and wrong information costs bands, which costs retests, which costs another Rs. 19,000.

This handbook is the complete Indian-edition starter kit. Every fee, rule and deadline in these pages comes from official sources — IDP IELTS India (the sole test operator in India), ielts.org and the published test terms — and each table carries its source. Around those facts is the part no website gives you in one place: how the band scale actually works, what each skill's question types demand, how examiners mark your writing and speaking, and an eight-week plan that takes you from a cold diagnostic to test day with a target band you have already scored in practice.

Read sections 2 to 10 first to understand the machine — which test you need, what it costs, how to book, how bands are calculated. Then work sections 11 to 24, the skill-by-skill operating manual. Sections 25 to 40 cover the plans, the worked examples in 41 to 44,, the money decisions — One Skill Retake, re-marking, coaching, the honest cost ledger — and the appendices collect every quick-reference table and a weekly review template.

WHAT THIS BOOK IS AND IS NOT

One promise before anything else: this handbook will not tell you IELTS is easy or that tricks replace English. What it will do is make sure that on test day, the only thing between you and your band is your English — not a booking mistake, a misread question type, or a strategy you never knew existed.

SECTION 02

What IELTS Is — and What It Is Not

IELTS — the International English Language Testing System — is jointly owned by the British Council, IDP IELTS and Cambridge University Press & Assessment. More than 12,000 organisations worldwide accept its scores: universities, professional bodies, employers and immigration authorities. Around four million tests are taken globally each year, and India is one of its largest markets.

Three facts reset most beginners' mental model. First, there is no pass or fail — you receive a band score from 0 to 9, and 'good enough' is whatever your target institution asks for. Second, in India the test is delivered exclusively by IDP Education (since 2021), so every booking, fee and rule in this handbook comes from IDP's Indian operation — the British Council's Indian booking role has ended, though its free study materials are still excellent. Third, IELTS is a language test, not a knowledge test: it checks how you use English in academic and everyday contexts, which is why preparation improves scores so reliably.

Two formats coexist: IELTS on Computer (Listening, Reading and Writing typed at a centre, results typically in 3-5 days) and IELTS on Paper (results around 13 days). The Speaking test is always a live conversation with a human examiner, whatever format you choose. Note that the IELTS partners have

been moving the test to computer delivery, with announcements of paper withdrawal in India through 2026 — confirm the formats your nearest centre currently offers when you book, and if both exist, prefer computer: identical content, faster results, more date options, and eligibility for the One Skill Retake explained in section 37.

SECTION 03

Which IELTS Do You Need? Four Tests, One Decision

The most expensive beginner mistake in IELTS is booking the wrong test. There are four products under the IELTS name, and universities and visa offices are not forgiving about mix-ups.

Test	Who it is for	Fee (2026)
IELTS Academic	University admission and professional registration abroad (the default for students)	Rs. 19,000
IELTS General Training	Work, training programmes and migration to Canada, Australia, NZ and the UK	Rs. 19,000
IELTS for UKVI	UK visa categories that require a Secure English Language Test (SELT) — confirm on gov.uk before booking	Rs. 19,250
IELTS Life Skills (A1 / B1)	UK family and settlement visas only — a short speaking-and-listening test, not the four-skill exam	Rs. 18,000

Source: IDP IELTS India fee schedule, effective 1 April 2026 (ieltsidpindia.com).

Choose Academic if you are going to study; General Training if you are migrating for work. If your destination is a UK visa, check whether your specific visa route demands the UKVI-approved version — it costs only Rs. 250 more but is a different product, and taking the regular test for a UKVI-mandatory route means rebooking at full price. When in doubt, the requirement is always stated by the university or the visa page, never by the coaching centre advising you.

SECTION 04

The 2026 Fee Structure: What Rs. 19,000 Buys

The headline fee rose by Rs. 1,000 to Rs. 19,000 on 1 April 2026, and it is uniform — the same in every Indian city, for Academic and General Training alike, on computer and paper. What varies is everything around the headline number.

Item	Fee (2026)	What to know
IELTS Academic / General (computer or paper)	Rs. 19,000	Same price across all cities and centres
IELTS for UKVI	Rs. 19,250	Only for UK visa routes requiring a SELT
IELTS Life Skills (A1 / B1)	Rs. 18,000	Speaking + listening only, for UK family visas
One Skill Retake	Rs. 12,650	Retake one skill instead of all four — see section 37
Transfer / reschedule	Rs. 4,750	Rs. 4,850 for UKVI; Rs. 3,200 for One Skill Retake; Rs. 4,500 Life Skills

Item	Fee (2026)	What to know
Cancellation	Refund minus deductions	Only when cancelled well ahead of the date; no refund close to the test
Enquiry on Results (re-mark)	Roughly Rs. 14,000	Refunded fully if your band increases — see section 38

Source: IDP IELTS India published fees (April 2026); cancellation policies vary by notice period — verify the exact terms on your booking portal before paying.

Two behavioural notes the fee table hides. First, there are no instalments and no student discounts — the full fee is due at booking, and every retest is full price again, which is why preparation (this handbook costs less than 0.6% of a retest) is the cheapest score improvement available. Second, book your own test: third-party agents sometimes add service charges on top of IDP's price for doing what this handbook's section 6 walks you through in ten minutes.

SECTION 05

The Band Scale: What 0-9 Actually Means

You receive a band from 0 to 9 for each of the four skills, and an overall band rounded to the nearest half. There is no pass mark — a band 6 is not a failure and a band 8 is not a distinction; they are simply levels on a published scale describing what you can do in English.

Band	User level	What it means in practice
9	Expert	Fully operational command; precise, fluent, complete understanding
8	Very good	Fully operational with only occasional errors or misunderstandings
7	Good	Operational command despite occasional inaccuracies; handles complex language well
6	Competent	Effective command despite some errors; can use fairly complex language
5	Modest	Partial command; copes with overall meaning in most situations, many errors
4	Limited	Basic competence limited to familiar situations; frequent problems
3 / 2 / 1	Extremely limited / intermittent / non-user	Conveys and understands only general meaning in very familiar situations; communication breaks down

Source: band scale descriptions, ielts.org.

For calibration: most Indian test takers land between 5.5 and 7. Typical university admissions sit at overall 6.0 to 7.0; some competitive programmes and professional registrations ask for 7.0 with minimums in each skill. The gap between a 6.5 and a 7 is the most expensive half-band in the test — it is the difference between 'competent' and 'good' on the descriptor scale, and it usually lives in Writing, the section that most Indian candidates under-prepare.

SECTION 06

How the Overall Band Is Calculated

The overall band is the average of your four skill scores, rounded to the nearest half band. The rounding rule has a bite worth learning before test day: averages ending in .25 round UP to .5, and averages ending in .75 round UP to the next whole band — so a quarter of the time, the rounding helps you.

Listening	Reading	Writing	Speaking	Average	Overall band
6.5	6.0	6.0	6.0	6.125	6.0
7.0	7.0	6.5	6.5	6.750	7.0
7.5	7.0	6.0	6.0	6.625	6.5
6.0	6.0	5.5	6.5	6.000	6.0

Arithmetic on the official rule: average of four skills, rounded to the nearest 0.5; .25 and .75 round up.

Read the second row again, because it is the single most useful planning fact in IELTS: a candidate one half-band weak in Writing and Speaking still reaches overall 7.0 if Listening and Reading are strong. Reading and Listening are objective papers — right answers are right — and Indian test takers with school-trained comprehension routinely pull 7.5-plus there. That surplus subsidises the productive skills. Your target sheet should therefore carry per-skill targets, not one overall number, and the smartest allocation is usually: harvest Listening and Reading for 7+, then defend Writing and Speaking at 6-6.5.

SECTION 07

Booking the Test: The Ten-Minute Walkthrough

All Indian bookings happen at ieltsidpindia.com. The process is genuinely simple; the traps are all in the details around it.

- 1 Create your account and verify it before you intend to book — accounts can take time to activate.
- 2 Choose the test (Academic or General Training; UKVI only if your UK visa route demands it) and the format (computer recommended, where offered).
- 3 Pick your city and test centre, then a date from the live calendar — green dates are open.
- 4 Enter your personal details exactly as they appear on your passport; in India the valid passport is the only accepted identity document, and mismatches invalidate bookings.
- 5 Upload a clear colour scan of the passport (keep the file under the size limit the portal states).
- 6 Pay the Rs. 19,000 fee online — card, net banking, UPI — or use the offline routes (demand draft or bank deposit at approved banks) if you must.
- 7 Save the confirmation email; for computer-delivered tests your Speaking slot details arrive close to test day (typically around two days before) if not chosen at booking.

Timing advice with money attached: book four to six weeks ahead in the metros — Delhi, Mumbai, Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Chennai — where slots fill fastest, and earlier still for July-August, the peak study-abroad season. Booking early also creates the one thing an effective plan needs: a real date. And a word on the calendar: computer IELTS runs almost daily at major centres; paper dates are fewer and vanishing. Choose the date by your application deadlines minus result time (3-5 days for computer)

minus a retake buffer of at least a month, so a bad morning does not derail an intake.

SECTION 08

Test Day: Format, Timing and the Computer Experience

The three written skills run in one sitting of about 2 hours 45 minutes; Speaking is separate, sometimes the same day, sometimes within a window around it. Here is the shape of the day.

Skill	Format	Time	Questions / Tasks
Listening	4 recordings, played once only	~30 minutes	40 questions
Reading	Academic: 3 long passages / GT: 3 sections	60 minutes	40 questions
Writing	Task 1 (150+ words) then Task 2 (250+ words)	60 minutes	2 tasks
Speaking	Face-to-face with an examiner, 3 parts	11-14 minutes	—

Source: test format, ielts.org. On paper the Listening test also included answer-transfer time; on computer you type as you listen.

On the computer: you can type, edit and reorder — a genuine advantage for Writing — but you cannot annotate the text as richly as on paper. Practise the digital format with official sample tests before the day; half of the computer-format anxiety is simply never having typed an essay under a clock. Carry the same passport you registered with, reach the centre early, and expect biometric checks and a strict no-electronics regime from the waiting room onward.

SECTION 09

Listening: The Structure and the Once-Only Rule

Four recordings of increasing difficulty: a conversation in an everyday social context; a monologue in an everyday setting; a conversation in an academic or training context (up to four speakers); and an academic monologue, typically a lecture extract. You hear each recording exactly once — the single most important fact in the section, because every strategy below exists to serve it.

The 40 questions come in types you can train in advance: form, note and table completion; multiple choice; matching; map, plan and diagram labelling; and sentence completion. The answers arrive in question order — the recording moves forward and never comes back — so a lost question must be abandoned instantly or it will cascade into the next three. Band 7 in Listening typically means around 30-32 correct out of 40; band 6 around 23-26 — approximate bands that vary slightly with each test's difficulty, but they calibrate your practice honestly.

Spelling and plurals count. A right idea spelled wrong scores zero, and so does 'year' where the speaker said 'years'. If you have ever been careless with 'accommodation' (two cs, two ms) or 'Wednesday', the Listening section is where that habit becomes expensive. The word-limit instructions are literal: a three-word answer of four words scores nothing.

SECTION 10

Listening: Strategy for a Once-Only Recording

The core skill is reading ahead of the audio. In the seconds before each recording and the pauses between questions, your eyes should be on the questions you are about to face, not the ones just past — knowing that question 14 needs a place name primes your ear to catch exactly that.

- **Underline the keyword in every question before the audio starts** — usually a noun or a name. You listen for the keyword's paraphrase, never the exact word; IELTS paraphrases by design.
- **Predict the answer type** from the gap: a date, a number, a surname, a course name. Knowing what class of word you need halves the processing load.
- **Watch for the traps the test is built on** — the speaker corrects themselves ('it's Tuesday... no, sorry, Wednesday'), or gives two candidates before confirming one. The final correction is usually the answer.
- **Abandon lost questions instantly.** One blank skipped is one blank; three blanks from lingering on the first is a band.
- **Never leave a blank at the end.** There is no negative marking in IELTS — a guess is free expected value, always.
- **Use the transfer-proof habit on computer:** you type as you listen, so keep half an eye on the screen; a brilliant answer typed into the wrong question number is a lost answer.

THE ERROR LOG

The daily drill that works: one IELTS-style listening passage a day, under exam conditions, with an error log that separates 'did not hear', 'heard but did not understand', 'understood but spelled wrong' and 'lost position in the recording'. The first two are comprehension; the last two are free marks leaking — and the log tells you which problem you actually have.

SECTION 11

Listening: The Question Types, One by One

Train the formats separately — each has a distinct failure mode and a distinct drill.

- **Form / note / table completion** (Parts 1 and 2): the easiest marks in the test, made of names, numbers, dates and spellings. Drill: number-and-spelling sets — letters of the alphabet, teen-versus-ty (13 vs 30), phone numbers, postcodes — until reflexive.
- **Map / plan / diagram labelling**: you track a speaker walking a building or describing a layout. Drill: orient yourself to the map's entrance and compass before the audio; the speaker's 'as you come in, on your left' is spatial language you can pre-study.
- **Multiple choice with pictures**: eliminate while listening — the wrong options are usually things that sound the same or relate to a nearby wrong candidate.
- **Matching (information to speakers)**: the trap is a keyword appearing in two speakers' lines. Drill: match on the speaker's final decision or emphasis, not the first mention.
- **Sentence completion (Parts 3-4)**: academic vocabulary in context, still capped by a word limit. Drill: subject-lecture vocabulary — 'hypothesis', 'findings', 'drawback', 'in retrospect' — the Part 4 accent of the test.

A useful benchmark before test day: in practice, you should be scoring band-7-equivalent (~30+/40) on Parts 1-2 and band-6.5 on Parts 3-4 alone before the full paper plays at your target. The paper's difficulty curve is deliberate — the first two parts are harvest, the last two are the band you are actually applying for.

SECTION 12

Reading Academic: Three Passages, Forty Questions

Three long authentic texts — from books, journals, magazines and newspapers — increase in difficulty across the hour; passage three is deliberately the hardest. Forty questions in sixty minutes means the section is a time-management test as much as a comprehension test: 90 seconds per question including reading, and no extra time to transfer answers.

Band conversion runs similar to Listening: roughly 30-32 correct for band 7, 23-26 for band 6, varying slightly by paper. The efficient pattern most band-7+ candidates converge on is 20 minutes per passage with the last two minutes spent on the questions they flagged — and a hard rule that passage three never receives less time simply because it comes last and is hardest. Reading is also where school-trained Indians have a sleeping advantage: years of dense-textbook comprehension converts directly to band 7 when the strategy catches up with the ability.

SECTION 13

Reading: The Question Types and How to Kill Each One

Every IELTS Reading question is one of a known set. Train them as separate skills, because each has its own trap.

Question type	The trap	The method
True / False / Not Given	Guessing Not Given when the text is silent	The statement is True only if the text states it; False only if the text contradicts it; anything else — including what you know from outside — is Not Given
Matching Headings	Choosing a heading by its keyword	The heading must summarise the paragraph's whole point, not share a word with it; read the paragraph's first and last sentences first
Multiple Choice	Options that are true of the passage but not answers	Eliminate options that are not answered by the specific question asked
Summary / Note / Table completion	Copying a word not in the text	The answer must come from the passage, fit the grammar, and respect the word limit exactly
Matching Information (paragraph letters)	Time collapse — hunting the whole passage per item	Do these after the other questions for that passage, when you already know where things live
Sentence Endings	A grammatically fine but wrong meaning	Read for logic, not grammar fit; eliminate endings whose meaning contradicts the passage
Short-answer questions	Over-writing	Respect the word limit — keywords only

Question types per the official format; strategies are standard high-scoring practice.

The universal law across all types: IELTS paraphrases. The question almost never repeats the passage's words, so matching keywords blindly fails — you match meaning. Train one question type at a time until its trap no longer catches you, then mix. The improvement shows up within two weeks of deliberate practice, which is faster than any other section of the test.

SECTION 14

Reading: Time, Skimming and the 20-Minute Passage

Two habits decide Reading bands more than vocabulary does. The first is the skim-then-scan protocol: 60-90 seconds skimming the passage for its structure — topic, the author's stance, where each idea lives — before touching questions, so that every later question is a lookup, not a reread. The second is the flag-and-return rule: any question that resists 45 seconds gets flagged and abandoned until the passage's easier questions are done.

What does not work is reading the passage word-by-word first — three minutes per passage, then re-reading to answer, which doubles the work and halves the time. And what ruins otherwise strong papers is the last-question panic: candidates leave the hardest passage with eight minutes and rush its ten questions. Guard passage three's twenty minutes like a deposit. If you finish early, spend the surplus on flagged questions, not on second-guessing confirmed answers — your first answer is right more often than your nervous second one.

SECTION 15

Reading General Training: The Difference

General Training reading has three sections instead of three passages: Section 1 holds two or three short everyday texts (notices, advertisements, timetables), Section 2 holds two work-related texts (contracts, staff policies), and Section 3 is one longer general-interest text of roughly academic difficulty. Same sixty minutes, same forty questions, same band scale.

The strategic consequence: GT's first two sections are fast marks — most candidates should clear them in under thirty minutes total, banking time for the long Section 3. The band conversion is also slightly stricter in GT (a band 7 typically needs a couple more correct answers than Academic), so GT candidates cannot coast on easy early sections. Everything in sections 12 and 13 — the question-type training, the skim-scan protocol, the flag-and-return rule — applies unchanged; GT is the same craft practised on friendlier early terrain.

SECTION 16

Writing Task 1 Academic: The 150-Word Data Description

Task 1 gives you a visual — a graph, table, chart or diagram, or a process — and twenty recommended minutes for at least 150 words. It is a technical description exercise, not an essay: what the data shows, the main trends, the key comparisons. It carries one-third of the Writing score, which means Task 2 carries double — a fact that dictates time allocation even though it is printed nowhere in the test room.

The four-move structure that satisfies the examiners: an opening sentence that paraphrases what the visual shows (never copy the prompt's words); an overview — one or two sentences naming the most striking trend or the main stages, with no numbers; the body, one or two paragraphs selecting and comparing the significant data points (the highest, the lowest, the sharpest change, the crossover — not every number on the chart); and precise vocabulary for movement — rose, declined, fluctuated, plateaued — with the language of comparison (twice as high as, marginally greater) where it belongs.

The two classic failures: describing every data point (a catalogue, not an overview — the word 'overview' is literally in the band descriptors for the top bands) and writing your opinion (Task 1 Academic wants

description, never commentary). Practise by taking any chart from a business newspaper and writing its story in 160 words against a 20-minute clock.

SECTION 17

Writing Task 1 General Training: The Letter

General Training Task 1 is a letter of at least 150 words — formal, semi-formal or informal, decided by the prompt — built around three bullet points you must cover. The marks live in register: an informal letter to a friend that reads like a formal complaint, or vice versa, caps your band before the examiner reaches the second paragraph.

- **Decide the register first** from the recipient: a landlord or a company is formal ('I am writing to...'), a colleague is semi-formal, a friend is informal — contractions and warm openings included.
- **Open and close in register:** 'Dear Sir or Madam ... Yours faithfully' versus 'Hi Sam ... See you soon' — the wrong pairing is the fastest band-cap in the test.
- **Cover all three bullet points fully** — the examiner ticks them off; one covered thinly is a lost band criterion.
- **Use paragraphs:** one purpose per paragraph, mirroring the bullets, so the letter's structure is visible at a glance.

SECTION 18

Writing Task 2: The 250-Word Essay That Counts Double

Task 2 is a 250-word minimum essay in forty recommended minutes, worth double Task 1. You will face one of a few known shapes: opinion ('To what extent do you agree?'), discussion ('Discuss both views and give your opinion'), advantages-disadvantages, problem-solution, or two-part questions. The essay tests argument — position, support, structure — and it is where most Indian candidates' Writing band is decided.

The structure that works: a short introduction of two to three sentences that paraphrases the question and states your position plainly; two body paragraphs, each ONE idea developed with an explanation and a concrete example; and a conclusion that restates the position without new material. Four paragraphs, roughly 270-300 words. What fails: a position that never appears until the conclusion (the examiner should know your view by sentence two), one giant idea smearing across two paragraphs, and examples from a template ('a survey by XYZ says') — invented statistics are transparent and score nothing.

Prepare content, not just structure: Task 2 topics recycle around a small set of themes — education, technology, environment, health, work-life, cities, crime. Build a personal idea-bank of positions and examples for each theme during your prep weeks, and on test day you are assembling, not inventing. And budget ruthlessly: 40 minutes means five minutes of planning, thirty of writing, five of checking — the plan is not lost time, it is what stops the mid-essay stall.

SECTION 19

How Writing Is Marked: The Four Criteria

Examiners score both tasks against the same four public criteria, each worth 25% of the Writing score. Knowing them changes what you practise, because each one is a lever you can pull with structure rather than years of English study.

Criterion	What it rewards	The cheap improvement
Task Achievement / Response	Answering the question asked, fully, at length	Plan; cover every bullet/part; state your position early
Coherence and Cohesion	Clear paragraphs, logical flow, linking that serves meaning	One idea per paragraph; linking words used sparingly, not decoratively
Lexical Resource	Range, precision and collocation; errors that do not block meaning	Learn topic collocations (heavy traffic, not strong traffic); prefer the precise word to the fancy one
Grammatical Range and Accuracy	Sentence variety used correctly	Mix short and complex sentences; error-free simple beats error-strewn complex

Source: Writing assessment criteria (public band descriptors), ielts.org.

Read the third column twice: three of the four criteria respond to structure and planning, which is why Writing scores move so quickly with focused practice — a candidate who writes eight corrected essays typically climbs a half-band while a candidate who writes twenty unreviewed ones stays flat. The review is the practice; the writing is only the occasion for it.

SECTION 20

Writing: The Mistakes That Cap Indian Bands

These are the specific, repeated errors that hold capable Indian test takers at Writing 6.0. Every one of them is fixable in a fortnight of deliberate practice.

- 1 Writing around the question instead of answering it — elegant paragraphs that never take the position the prompt demanded.
- 2 The memorised-template opener ('In this contemporary era of globalisation...') — examiners are trained to discount it; it adds words and removes marks.
- 3 Length without development — padding a 300-word essay with the same idea restated three ways instead of a second idea with an example.
- 4 The invented statistic ('according to a recent survey, 80% of people') — no source, no marks, and a Lexical Resource penalty for the empty phrase.
- 5 Vocabulary showboating — 'utilise' for use, 'myriad' for many. Precision beats decoration on the descriptor scale; the wrong fancy word costs twice.
- 6 One paragraph essay and the wall of text — Coherence and Cohesion is 25% of the score and it is scored on paragraphing.
- 7 Under-length Task 2 — below 250 words is penalised directly, in bands, not fractions.
- 8 Spending thirty minutes on Task 1 and arriving at the double-weighted essay with twenty-five — the schedule error that caps everything.
- 9 Never checking — subject-verb agreement, plurals and articles (the a/an/the tax) are exactly what the final two-minute read catches.
- 10 Practising without review — the ten-essay-with-feedback plan beats the fifty-essay-in-a-silence plan every time.

SECTION 21

Vocabulary: What Actually Moves Lexical Resource

Lexical Resource — 25% of Writing and Speaking — is the criterion most candidates prepare worst. It does not reward rare words; it rewards precise words used naturally, in the company they keep. 'Heavy traffic', 'a growing concern', 'raise awareness' — these collocations are what band 7 looks like in practice, not 'myriad' and 'utilise'.

Build vocabulary by topic, by hand, from your reading. For every IELTS theme — environment, education, technology, health, work, cities — collect one page of collocations and topic phrases (not isolated words), each with one sentence you wrote yourself. Your own sentence is the whole trick: vocabulary enters active memory through use, and a list of unused words is decoration that evaporates on test day. Ten minutes of daily review, spaced across the eight weeks, outperforms any weekend binge.

For Writing specifically, add the language of data and argument: verbs of change (rose, dipped, fluctuated, plateaued), comparators (marginally, threefold, on par with), and opinion-connectors used sparingly (admittedly, on balance, by and large). For Speaking, add fillers-that-are-not-fillers — 'that's an interesting one', 'let me think for a second' — which buy thinking time while sounding engaged, a legitimate fluency tool the examiners hear as interaction, not avoidance.

SECTION 22

Grammar for Bands: The Short List That Pays

Grammatical Range and Accuracy is 25% of both productive skills, and its top descriptor asks for variety used correctly — which means error-free simple sentences beat error-strewn complex ones every single time. The good news: the grammar that moves bands is a short list, and your own error log already tells you which items on it are yours.

- **Subject-verb agreement** — 'the number of students is', 'many people believe' — the number-one Indian error, and pure gain from two final-minute checks per essay.
- **Articles (a / an / the)** — the famous tax on Indian English. Fix by drilling the specific patterns you personally get wrong, not by re-learning 'articles' as a chapter.
- **Tense discipline** — Task 1 past-tense for past data, present for the present; Part 2 stories in clean past tense throughout.
- **Two reliable complex structures** — a conditional and a relative clause ('which means that...') used deliberately, not a dozen deployed hopefully.
- **Punctuation that signals structure** — the comma before 'which', the full stop that refuses to run sentences together.

The method: keep a fix-list of your five recurring errors (your reviewed essays will name them within two submissions), and check every future piece of writing for exactly those five. Grammar repair works top-down, five errors at a time — the grammar textbook route takes months and moves nothing on test day.

SECTION 23

Speaking: The Three Parts

Speaking is a recorded 11-14 minute conversation with a certified examiner, in three parts of rising demand. It is marked live, and it rewards one thing above all: speech that keeps flowing naturally.

Part	Length	What happens
Part 1: Introduction and interview	4-5 minutes	Questions about you — home, work, studies, familiar topics like weather, hobbies, daily routine
Part 2: The long turn	3-4 minutes	A cue card (task card) with a topic; one minute to prepare with pencil and paper, then 1-2 minutes of uninterrupted talk, ending with a couple of follow-up questions
Part 3: Discussion	4-5 minutes	Abstract discussion linked to the Part 2 topic — opinions, comparisons, speculation about causes and futures

Source: Speaking test format, ielts.org.

Part 2 is where candidates freeze, so understand its design: the cue card gives a topic and three or four prompts, but you are not required to cover the prompts — they are scaffolding for a candidate who stalls. You may ignore them entirely and tell the story you can tell; fluency for the full two minutes is the target, and a structured, deliberate story beats a checklist recitation. Part 3 is the band differentiator: examiners push for depth ('Why do you think that is? What would change if...?') and the band 7+ answers generalise thoughtfully rather than repeating Part 1's simplicity.

SECTION 24

The Cue Card Bank: Twenty Themes, Prepared Honestly

Part 2 topics recycle around a fixed geography of themes. Prepare honest personal material for each — a story that is yours, with details only you would have — and the long turn stops being a lottery. The recurring territory:

- A person you admire · a teacher who influenced you · a family member with an interesting story
- A place you love · your hometown · a city you visited · a quiet spot you go to think
- An object you value · something you bought that you use every day · a photograph that matters to you
- An experience: a journey that went wrong · a time you helped someone · a skill you learned with difficulty
- Your studies or work · a subject you found hard and then liked · a project you were proud of
- Leisure: a book or film that stayed with you · a hobby you would teach someone · music you grew up with
- Practical: advice you received and ignored · a decision you took slowly · a habit you changed
- Imaginative: something you would learn if you had time · a place you want to visit and why

The preparation method for each: write nothing in sentences. Note five keywords — person, place, event, feeling, detail — and speak the story twice, recorded. On test day, the cue card will be some cousin of these themes, and what you will have is not a script (which examiners penalise) but a shelf of real stories you have already told twice. Fluency is largely memory with room to breathe.

SECTION 25

Speaking: What Actually Raises the Score

Speaking is marked against four criteria, each 25%: Fluency and Coherence, Lexical Resource, Grammatical Range and Accuracy, and Pronunciation. Note what is absent: accent. Pronunciation is scored on clarity — being effortless to understand — not on sounding British or American.

The preparation that moves these criteria is spoken volume, not study volume. The single highest-return habit is the daily two-minute recording: take a Part 2 cue card (hundreds circulate freely online), speak for two minutes into your phone, listen back once. You will hear your own fillers, your speed, your stalls — and the fix is obvious the moment you hear it. Two weeks of this does more than two months of silent vocabulary study, because Speaking is a motor skill wearing an exam's clothes.

Build the two banks during prep weeks: a topic bank (work, study, hometown, books, travel, technology, environment — prepare honest personal material for each Part 1 theme) and a phrase bank for discussion moves ('That said...', 'It depends heavily on...', 'The way I see it...'). Not scripts — you cannot and should not memorise answers (examiners hear memorised speech instantly and mark fluency down for it) — but ready-made movement language that keeps your speech flowing while your mind finds the next idea. The honest rule: on test day, the examiner should meet a relaxed person talking, not a candidate reciting.

SECTION 26

The Diagnostic: Find Your Baseline Before Anything Else

Week one has one job: find out, without paying Rs. 19,000 to learn it, roughly where you stand. Take a full official sample test under strict exam conditions — timed, uninterrupted, honest. Score Listening and Reading with the answer keys; for Writing and Speaking, be your own harsh examiner against the public band descriptors, or use a free feedback session if you can find one.

Then set targets with the averaging arithmetic from section 6. If your diagnostic reads L6.5, R6, W5.5, S6, your overall today is 6.0 and the shortest road to 7.0 is probably Reading and Listening to 7.5 with Writing and Speaking to 6.5 — a route through your strongest papers. The diagnostic also tells you which sections are strategy-poor rather than language-poor: a Listening 6 with three 'lost position' errors in the log is a 7 waiting for technique, while a Writing 5.5 with three idea-bank problems is a content project. Different problems, different plans — which is why every generic 'study 2 hours daily' plan underperforms.

SECTION 27

The 8-Week Plan: Diagnostic to Test Day

Eight weeks is the honest full-preparation window for a candidate within a band of target; six if the gap is a half-band and you can study daily. The plan assumes 1.5 to 2 focused hours on weekdays and 3 on weekends.

Weeks	The job	Exit milestone
1	Diagnostic; error log started; record a baseline Speaking cue card	You know your per-skill bands and your weakest question types

Weeks	The job	Exit milestone
2-3	One Listening + one Reading passage daily with log; question-type drills for your two worst types; Writing Task 1 structure practice (2 per week)	Error log shows the same trap types dying, not repeating
4-5	Task 2 essays (2 per week, reviewed); Speaking recordings daily; topic and phrase banks built; Listening/Reading alternate days	A reviewed essay hits your target band at least once
6	First full mock under exam conditions; autopsy; grammar fix-list from your own errors	Mock overall within half a band of target
7	Second full mock; timed Writing pairs (Task 1 + Task 2 in 60 minutes); Speaking simulations with a partner or recorded	Timing under control; Writing completes in the hour
8	One final mock early in the week; then light review of your error log and banks only; sleep discipline; no new material after day 3	You arrive rested, timed and calibrated

Scale the plan to your diagnostic: 6 weeks for a half-band gap, 10-12 for a full band.

The weekly review template in Appendix B is the plan's engine — ten minutes every Sunday, honestly filled, converts the schedule from a wish into a system. And the cardinal rule of the final week: no new material. New questions in the last days do not raise ability; they raise anxiety. You are polishing and sleeping, not cramming a language.

SECTION 28

Free Official Resources vs Paid Coaching

Everything you strictly need is free and official: ielts.org's sample questions and familiarisation material, IDP India's free preparation resources and masterclasses on ieltsidpindia.com, and the public band descriptors — the actual documents your examiners mark against. The paid ecosystem around the test divides into useful and decorative.

- **Worth paying for:** a book of authentic past-style practice tests (the Cambridge IELTS series is the standard — real past papers with keys), and, if your Writing is stuck, one round of expert feedback on 4-6 essays. Targeted spend, under a few thousand rupees.
- **Situational:** a coaching batch, if you know you will not self-study without structure or your diagnostic is two bands below target. Choose one that marks your writing and records your speaking — teaching-to-the-descriptors, not lecture series.
- **Not worth it:** 'guaranteed band' courses, prediction-question packs, and any service that books the test 'for you' at a markup. The test is not gameable, and section 7 already walked you through the booking yourself.

A realistic full self-study budget: this handbook, one practice-test book, and perhaps one feedback round — comfortably under Rs. 3,000 on top of the fee, against Rs. 15,000-25,000 for a typical coaching programme. Both routes reach the same band for disciplined candidates; only one of them requires discipline.

SECTION 29

Mock Tests: The Ritual, Not the Score

Mocks are instruments, and the score they print is their least useful output. The ritual that converts mocks into bands: full exam conditions (timed, no dictionary, one sitting, typed on computer if that is your format); an autopsy the same evening that files every error into the log's four categories; and a 48-hour rule — every missed concept or question type from the mock is re-drilled within two days, while the mistake is still warm.

Watch two trend lines across your mocks, not the raw score: accuracy per question type in Listening and Reading, and word-count-plus-timing in Writing. A mock score that rises while accuracy per type stays flat means the papers got easier, not you. The right trajectory into test week is two mocks within a half-band of target, with your two historically worst question types now performing at par. For Speaking, every recorded simulation counts as a mock — and the recording played back once is worth three played back never.

SECTION 30

Targets by Destination: What Your Band Actually Buys

Requirements are set by institutions and immigration authorities, not by IELTS — always verify on the official page of your target. But the typical bands below calibrate expectations and targets.

Destination / purpose	Typical requirement	Note
University admission (UK, Australia, NZ)	Overall 6.0-7.0	Competitive programmes often add per-skill minimums, commonly 6.0 each
University admission (Canada, USA)	Overall 6.5-7.0	US programmes frequently specify per-skill floors
Professional registration (nursing, medicine, accounting)	Overall 7.0+ with per-skill minimums	The strictest common requirement; check the regulator, not the university
Canada Express Entry (language points)	CLB-equivalent bands feed the points grid	Higher bands earn more immigration points; verify the current grid on official Canadian sources
UK visas (UKVI routes)	CEFR level per route (B1, B2, C1...)	Requires IELTS for UKVI if the route demands a SELT

Typical published requirements as of 2026 — always confirm with your specific institution or visa authority before booking.

Two consequences follow. First, set per-skill targets from the actual requirement — a '6.5 overall with no less than 6.0 each' offer is a different training problem from a bare '6.5 overall'. Second, know the repair routes before test day: One Skill Retake (section 37) exists precisely for the candidate who misses one skill by half a band — but its acceptance is not universal, and Canada's Express Entry is the notable case that does not currently accept it. Check your route's policy before relying on the safety net.

SECTION 31

Band 5.5 to 6.5: The Foundation Climb

A one-band climb from 5.5 is a different project from the half-band polish higher up the scale, and it responds to volume, not strategy alone. At this level the binding constraint is usually input: not enough English read or heard, so every output is translation rather than recall.

- **Daily listening input, twenty minutes minimum** — English podcasts or YouTube at natural speed with subtitles, then one re-listen without. Comprehension grows from exposure; strategy only organises what exposure built.
- **Daily reading input** — one article from a quality English publication, plus the ten-minute vocabulary ritual from section 20. Look up only the words that block meaning.
- **Fluency before accuracy** — at this band, keep speaking and keep writing; self-correction on the fly is a band-6 skill in itself. Silence and over-caution cost more than errors.
- **Own the easy marks first** — Listening Parts 1-2 and Reading Sections 1-2 are where a 5.5 candidate becomes a 6.0; the harvest strategy of section 6 still applies, just lower.
- **Extend the plan** — an honest one-band climb takes ten to twelve weeks, not eight. Booking the test early is still fine; booking it without the extra weeks is the retest fee with extra steps.

SECTION 32

Band 6.5 to 7.0: Closing the Most Expensive Half-Band

The gap between 6.5 and 7.0 is where most Indian test takers live for months. It is rarely a vocabulary problem; it is almost always four specific behaviours, and each has a drill.

- **Writing: the overview and the position.** Band 7 Task 1s have a clear overview; band 7 Task 2s state a position by the second sentence and develop ONE idea per paragraph. Drill: rewrite your last three essays to this shape and compare.
- **Listening: the paraphrase ear.** You miss answers not because the words were unfamiliar but because the question said 'postponed' and the recording said 'put back'. Drill: for every practice error, write down the question's wording and the recording's actual wording side by side.
- **Reading: the Not Given discipline.** The 6.5 candidate still confuses 'false' with 'not given'. Drill: a set of only T/F/NG questions, untimed, until three consecutive clean sets.
- **Speaking: the stretch.** Band 7 speech develops points with reasons and examples rather than restating them. Drill: answer every Part 3 question with point, reason, example — 30 seconds each, recorded.

SECTION 33

The Myths You Should Stop Believing Today

Every one of these circulates in Indian IELTS groups weekly, and every one of them is false or harmless-by-accident. Believing them costs preparation time that should have gone into practice.

- 1 'Some centres are easier than others.' The test is standardised and marking is centralised with quality control; the centre changes the chair, not the band.
- 2 'IDP tests are easier than British Council tests.' In India there is only IDP; globally, it is one test owned jointly by all three partners.

- 3 'Longer essays score higher.' Length adds error surface and risks the Task 2 schedule; quality and structure score, not word count.
- 4 'Big words impress examiners.' Lexical Resource rewards precision and collocation; misused rare words cost twice.
- 5 'A British or American accent is required.' Pronunciation is scored on intelligibility, never on accent — Indian English spoken clearly is fully credited.
- 6 'You must memorise templates.' Memorised speech is detected and marked down for fluency; prepared ideas are credited, prepared wording is not.
- 7 'Computer tests are marked by software.' Listening and Reading are machine-scored objectively; Writing and Speaking are always marked by trained human examiners against public descriptors.
- 8 'Speaking examiners want to trick you.' They ask follow-ups to give you room, not to catch you; the test is designed for you to show range.

SECTION 34

For Working Professionals: The Ten-Hour Week

A full job and IELTS preparation coexist if the ten weekly hours are placed correctly. The architecture that survives Indian working life:

Slot	Time	What it carries
Commute (both ways)	40-60 min/day	Listening practice — podcasts at natural speed, then IELTS audio; the commute is the Listening gym
Morning, before work	30 min/day	Vocabulary and phrase-bank review — ten minutes of words, twenty of reading input
Three weekday evenings	45 min each	The drill of the week: question types Mon, essay Wed, cue cards Fri — alternate skills
Weekend morning (Saturday)	2 hours	The week's full timed set or mock, with the same-evening autopsy
Sunday evening	10 min	The weekly review (Appendix B); next week's drill list fixed

Ten honest hours a week, held for eight weeks, reaches a half-band climb from a solid base.

Two working-candidate rules. Book the test around a quieter period at work if you can — the final two weeks before test day deserve intact evenings. And defend the weekend block harder than any other: it is the only slot long enough for a full mock, and mocks are where the ten scattered hours become one calibrated score.

SECTION 35

Test Day and the Week Before It

The final week is logistics and sleep, in that order of anxiety and reverse order of importance.

- 1 Confirm your test date, centre and reporting time from the official confirmation; plan the travel route with a fat buffer.
- 2 Check your passport validity and take the same physical passport you registered with — it is the only ID accepted, and a mismatch means no test, no refund.

- 3 In the last 72 hours, do a light review of your error log, your phrase bank and two recorded cue cards. Nothing new.
- 4 Sleep on schedule for the final three nights — the Listening paper opens the day, and it opens once.
- 5 Test morning: eat, arrive early, leave the phone at home or switched off well before entry, and carry only what the confirmation permits.
- 6 Between test components, if Speaking is on another day, do not post-mortem the written papers with fellow candidates; it poisons the half of the test you can still influence.

WHEN TO ACTUALLY BOOK THE TEST

If your target is 7.0 and your mock range is 6.5-7.0, take the test. Bands carry honest uncertainty of about a quarter-band, and postponing to feel 'fully ready' costs intake deadlines more often than it gains score. The reverse is also true: never sit the real test as your first full-length mock — that is a Rs. 19,000 practice session.

SECTION 36

After the Test: Results, TRF and Sending Scores

Computer-delivered results typically arrive in 3-5 calendar days (paper around 13), visible in your online portal first. The Test Report Form — your official score document — carries your four skill bands and the overall, and remains valid for two years from the test date. Institutions that receive results electronically get them directly; you choose where scores go, and both an original and any later One Skill Retake TRF remain available for verification.

Plan your calendar backwards from this machinery: application deadline, minus result time, minus a retake buffer (a month is comfortable; six weeks is safe), equals the latest sensible test date — and book earlier than that, because metro slots fill. If the score lands below requirement, the decision tree is short: one skill short and within 60 days — One Skill Retake (section 37); genuinely mis-marked feeling — Enquiry on Results (section 38); a real gap in two or more skills — a targeted re-preparation block and a full retest, using your error log as the syllabus.

SECTION 37

If This Is Your Retake: The Diagnostic Before You Repay Rs. 19,000

A disappointing result is information, and like all information it is worthless until diagnosed. Before booking a second attempt, find out precisely what the first one died of — because the three failure modes have three different cures.

- 1 **One skill short by half a band** — the OSR case (section 37): if you are within the 60-day window and took the computer test, a Rs. 12,650 single-skill retake beats a Rs. 19,000 retest, subject to your target's acceptance policy.
- 2 **Strategy marks lost** — timing collapses, lost position in Listening, False-versus-Not-Given errors: these are fixable in two to three weeks of the drills in sections 12, 13 and 10, and the retest should be booked exactly that far out.

- 3 **A real language gap in two or more skills** — the honest case for the foundation climb (section 30): extend to ten or twelve weeks of input volume, or the retest simply re-shoots the same film.

And keep the first result in perspective: it stays on no public record — only you choose which TRF to send to institutions. A failed first attempt is a private tuition fee toward a correctly prepared second one, and thousands of candidates each year convert exactly that distance into their required band on the next sitting. The only unforgivable version is rebooking without changing anything.

SECTION 38

One Skill Retake: The Rs. 12,650 Repair Option

One Skill Retake (OSR) is IELTS's best recent innovation for the Indian test taker: if one skill falls short, you can retake just that one — Listening, Reading, Writing or Speaking — instead of all four. The rules are strict, and knowing them before you book your main test changes your booking itself.

Rule	Detail
Eligibility	Only after a full IELTS on Computer (paper tests do not qualify) at a centre offering OSR, once you have your results
Window	Book and sit the retake within 60 days of the original test date — no exceptions
Frequency	One retake per original full test; one skill only
Fee (India)	Rs. 12,650 (Rs. 3,200 to reschedule an OSR booking)
Result	A new TRF with the retaken skill's new score plus the original three skills — in 3-5 days; you choose which TRF to use
Validity	Two years from the original test date, not the retake date
Re-marking	An Enquiry on Results is permitted against the One Skill Retake skill

Source: IDP IELTS India and ielts.org One Skill Retake terms (2026).

The strategic notes: because OSR exists only for computer-delivered tests, it is a standalone argument for choosing the computer format at booking. Because the new score — higher or lower — is what the new TRF shows, prepare for the retake like a real test, not a formality; you keep both TRFs, so a worse retake cannot hurt you, but a wasted one cannot be repeated. And the acceptance caveat that matters most for Indians: OSR is accepted by universities and regulators in Australia, New Zealand and the UK (including for UKVI in selected locations), but Canada's immigration authority does not currently accept it for Express Entry — verify your specific route's policy before banking on the safety net.

SECTION 39

Enquiry on Results: When Re-Marking Makes Sense

If you believe your result does not reflect your performance, you can request an Enquiry on Results (EOR) — a re-mark of one or all skills by a senior examiner, applied for within six weeks of your test date, typically taking up to around three weeks. The fee (recently in the region of Rs. 12,000-14,000) is refunded in full if any band increases. Verify the exact current fee on your booking portal before applying.

When it makes sense: a score wildly out of line with your mock history in one skill, or a Writing/Speaking band that dropped sharply versus a previous attempt. When it does not: when the result matches your

mocks and the disappointment is grief rather than evidence — the re-mark will confirm the original, the fee stays with the test owners, and the weeks lost could have been a retake. Note the interaction with the previous section: you cannot have an EOR and a One Skill Retake running against the same test at once, and an EOR on the original test must be resolved before a retake is booked against it. Choose your repair route once, deliberately.

SECTION 40

The Twelve Mistakes That Cost Indian Test-Takers Bands

Every one of these appears thousands of times a month in Indian results, and every one is avoidable before test day.

- 1 Booking General Training for a university application — or Academic for a migration route — because a consultant defaulted to it.
- 2 Booking the regular test where a UKVI-approved version was required by the specific visa route.
- 3 Registering with details that do not match the passport exactly, and losing the date (and the fee) to identity checks.
- 4 Taking the test as a first mock — never having sat a full timed paper before the real one.
- 5 Ignoring the word limits — the 150/250 minimums and the one-word/three-word answer caps are scored, literally.
- 6 Spelling and plurals leaking marks in Listening — right answers, wrong letters.
- 7 Reading the passage word-by-word before the questions, then reading it twice more to find answers.
- 8 Confusing False with Not Given — the single most common Reading band-cap in India.
- 9 The memorised essay template, the invented survey statistic, and other transparent score-signalers.
- 10 Writing Task 1 for thirty minutes and starving the double-weighted Task 2.
- 11 Preparing Speaking silently — vocabulary lists, no recordings — and meeting the first real examiner as the first-ever listener.
- 12 Leaving no retake buffer between test date and application deadline, then discovering the result landed two days after the intake closed.

SECTION 41

FAQ: The Questions Every Indian Test Taker Asks

Q. How many times can I take IELTS?

A. As many as you like — there is no limit and no mandatory gap, but every attempt is a fresh full fee. The design answer to a miss is usually One Skill Retake, not a full retest.

Q. How long are scores valid?

A. Two years from the test date — including a One Skill Retake score, which is valid from the original test date, not the retake.

Q. Is IELTS on Computer harder than on Paper?

A. No — the content, questions and marking are identical. The differences are mechanical: typing versus handwriting, screen highlighting versus pencil, results in 3-5 days versus about 13, and computer-only eligibility for One Skill Retake.

Q. Can I choose my Speaking date?

A. Often, yes — computer-delivered bookings typically let you select or are assigned a Speaking slot around the written date, with details near test day. When booking, check whether your centre allows slot selection.

Q. Is a British accent required in Speaking?

A. No. Pronunciation is marked on clarity and intelligibility, never on accent. Indian English, spoken clearly and confidently, loses nothing.

Q. Which is harder, IDP or British Council?

A. In India, IDP is the only operator — British Council stopped booking tests here in 2021. Globally, the test is one product; the papers differ only by date.

Q. Can I take IELTS from home?

A. IELTS Online exists in some markets; check availability for India on the official portal at booking time. Most Indian candidates still take the centre-based computer test.

Q. What is a good score?

A. There is no pass mark. University admission typically asks 6.0-7.0 overall; professional registration can ask 7.0 with per-skill minimums. Your 'good' is your target institution's published number.

Q. How soon should I book?

A. Four to six weeks ahead in metros, more in the July-August peak — and backwards from your application deadline with a result-time and retake-buffer subtracted.

Q. Can I prepare in one month?

A. If your diagnostic is within half a band of target, yes — a compressed version of the 8-week plan. If the gap is a band or more, one month of panic mostly buys a retest fee.

Q. Do coaching centres book the test for me?

A. You can book through offline partners, but the online booking in section 7 takes ten minutes and avoids service markups. Registering yourself also means you control dates, receipts and the portal.

Q. What if I miss my test?

A. No-shows forfeit the fee. Genuine emergencies are handled case-by-case by the centre — but the safe rule is to cancel or reschedule as early as possible (the transfer fee is Rs. 4,750) rather than simply not appear.

SECTION 42**Worked Example: A Band-7-Shaped Task 2, Annotated**

Below is a skeleton of a Task 2 answer to a typical prompt, annotated move by move. It is a shape, not a sample to memorise — the point is to see what each sentence is doing, so your own essays start with this architecture already built.

THE PROMPT

Prompt: 'Some people believe university education should be free for all students, while others believe students should pay for it. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.' (Write at least 250 words.)

Introduction (3 sentences). Sentence 1 paraphrases: 'Whether a degree should be state-funded or paid for by the student is debated in many countries.' Sentence 2 signals structure: 'This essay examines both positions before arguing that a subsidised system with means-tested fees serves society best.' Sentence 3 is optional padding — cut it. Annotation: the position is visible by the second sentence; the examiner never wonders where you stand; nothing is copied from the prompt.

Body 1 (one view, fully). Topic sentence: 'Those who support free education usually argue from equality of opportunity.' Explanation: two or three sentences — talent is spread across income groups, and fees exclude capable students from poorer households. Example: one concrete sentence — a real or plainly hypothetical case ('a first-generation student who drops out for financial reasons takes a society-funded seat and returns nothing'). Link or mini-close. Annotation: one idea, developed with an explanation and one example — not four ideas listed.

Body 2 (the other view, equally). Topic sentence: 'Opponents counter that free degrees are regressive in practice.' Explanation: general taxation funds the universitying of the already-advantaged; and zero price can cheapen the choice of course. Example: one sentence. Mini-close acknowledging the view's strength before your position lands in the conclusion. Annotation: fairness to both sides is a band-7 descriptor behaviour — the essay is a weighing, not a rant.

Conclusion (2 sentences). Restate the position with its reason: 'A fully free system overstates the public benefit, while full fees exclude talent — hence a subsidised middle path with means-tested support.' No new material. Annotation: about 270-290 words total, four paragraphs, five minutes of planning visible in the structure and invisible in the prose.

Run your own next essay against this skeleton: can you name the job of each sentence you wrote? If yes, you are writing band-7-shaped answers, and the remaining work is language. If no, the fix is structural, cheap, and takes one afternoon.

SECTION 43

Worked Example: A Task 1 Academic Answer, Annotated

Task 1 discipline is easier to see than to describe. The prompt: a line graph showing internet users as a share of population in two countries, 2000 to 2020, in 20-year bands. The 150-word answer has four moves.

- 1 Paraphrased opening: 'The graph compares the proportion of people using the internet in Country A and Country B between 2000 and 2020.' One sentence, no words copied from the prompt, no data yet.
- 2 The overview — the band-7 move: 'Overall, access grew in both countries, though Country A rose far more steeply and overtook Country B in the second decade.' No numbers, just the story's headline. If the examiner read only this sentence, they would still know the graph.

- 3 Body paragraph 1 — the significant data: the starting points (2000: A at one in ten, B at three in ten), the crossover year, and the endpoint gap. Selected figures only, with comparison language ('three times as high as', 'a widening gap').
- 4 Body paragraph 2 — the second feature: the one anomaly worth noting (a plateau in B between 2010 and 2015, a dip in A in 2005), because the top descriptors reward noticing what is unusual, not cataloguing every point.

The three sins this shape prevents: writing every number (catalogue mode), writing an opinion ('this growth is wonderful' — never), and no overview (the single most common reason a competent answer stalls at 6.0 in Task Achievement). Twenty minutes, about 160 words, and the clock is the examiner's ally — brevity chosen by design is not brevity imposed by time.

SECTION 44

The Signpost Language Bank

Both Listening and Reading reward knowing the language the test uses to signal structure. These phrases are the traffic lights of every recording and passage — hear or see them, and you know what is coming next.

Signal	What it tells you
'Moving on to...', 'Now, let's look at...'	A new section or question group begins — reset your attention forward
'One more thing', 'Before I finish...'	Late detail, often the last answer's zone — stay awake to the end
'Actually, sorry — I should have said...'	A correction is coming; the FINAL version is the answer
'To sum up', 'In conclusion'	Recording or passage closing; nothing new will be asked from here
'However', 'That said', 'In contrast'	The direction is reversing — a Listening trap or a Reading True/False pivot
'For instance', 'such as'	An example follows; examples rarely carry answers themselves, but confirm them
Numbers twice ('in 1998 — that's 98')	A dictated date or code; the second version is for your spelling

Standard discourse markers used across IELTS recordings and academic texts.

Drill this bank into recognition, not recall: on your next three practice recordings, tick off each signpost as you hear it. Within a week the phrases become reflexes and you stop losing position in the recording — which, for most candidates, is worth more than a hundred hours of vocabulary study.

SECTION 45

Glossary: The Jargon Decoded

Term	Meaning
Band	Your score for a skill or overall, 0 to 9, in halves — there is no pass mark
TRF (Test Report Form)	The official score document; valid two years from the test date
Overall band	Average of the four skill bands, rounded to the nearest half
IDP	IDP Education — sole IELTS test operator in India since 2021

Term	Meaning
UKVI / SELT	UK Visas and Immigration / Secure English Language Test — special UK visa routes needing an approved test
CEFR	The Common European Framework (A1-C2) that visa routes reference; IELTS bands map onto it
CLB	Canadian Language Benchmarks — the scale Canada's points system uses, converted from IELTS bands
OSR (One Skill Retake)	Retaking a single skill within 60 days of a computer-delivered test, for Rs. 12,650
EOR (Enquiry on Results)	A paid re-mark by a senior examiner, refunded if any band rises
Cue card	The Part 2 Speaking task card: a topic with prompts and one minute of preparation
Collocation	Words that naturally travel together ('heavy rain'); the unit Lexical Resource actually rewards
Band descriptors	The public marking criteria for Writing and Speaking — ielts.org publishes them; so should you read them
Not Given	The Reading answer when the text neither states nor contradicts the statement

Terms as used by IDP IELTS India, ielts.org and UK/Canadian immigration sources.

SECTION 46

The Speaking Practice Bank: Part 1 and Part 3, Prepared

Part 2 gets all the fear, but Parts 1 and 3 are twenty of your thirty-five possible marks. Both are predictable enough to prepare honestly — which is not the same as rehearsing lines, which examiners detect and discount.

Part 1 (4-5 minutes): questions about you across familiar themes. For each theme below, prepare three or four sentences of true material — a fact, a reason, a small detail only you would supply — and practise saying it aloud once. The recurring territory: your work or studies (what, why, what next); your hometown (what it is known for, what has changed, whether you would return); your home (the place you live, favourite room, your neighbourhood); daily routine and weekends; food and cooking; weather and seasons; hobbies and how you started them; books, films and music; travel near and far; phones and technology; shopping; friends; sport and exercise. Three or four sentences per theme is enough — Part 1 rewards directness, not speeches.

Part 3 (4-5 minutes): abstract discussion that climbs with each follow-up. The examiner's question shapes repeat across topics, and each shape has a natural answering movement:

- **'Why do people...?'** — give the two strongest reasons, not five; a sentence of example for one of them.
- **'What are the advantages and disadvantages...?'** — one of each, developed, then your own weighting ('overall I think the benefit outweighs...').
- **'How has X changed in your country?'** — then versus now, with one concrete marker of the change, ending with direction ('and it is still moving that way').

- **'Do you think X will... in the future?'** — a clear prediction, its main driver, and one honest uncertainty.
- **'Should the government...?'** — position, the strongest counter-argument, and your reply to it — the discussion move that separates band 7 speech from band 6.

Drill Part 3 in the same recorded format as everything else: one question, thirty seconds, point-reason-example. Two weeks of this and the follow-ups stop being pressure and start being room — which is exactly how the examiners design them.

SECTION 47

Appendix A: Quick-Reference Tables

Fact	Value
Fee, Academic / General (2026)	Rs. 19,000 — same in every Indian city
Fee, UKVI / Life Skills	Rs. 19,250 / Rs. 18,000
One Skill Retake	Rs. 12,650 — computer tests only, within 60 days, one skill per test
Reschedule (transfer)	Rs. 4,750 (Rs. 3,200 for OSR)
Enquiry on Results	Approx. Rs. 12,000-14,000; refunded if any band rises; within 6 weeks of test
Booking portal (India)	ieltsidpindia.com — IDP is the sole operator
Accepted ID (India)	Valid passport only; details must match exactly
Test length	~2h 45m (Listening, Reading, Writing) + 11-14 min Speaking
Results	Computer: 3-5 days · Paper: ~13 days · OSR: 3-5 days
Score validity	2 years from test date
Overall band	Average of 4 skills, rounded to nearest 0.5 (.25 and .75 round up)
Band 7 conversion (approx.)	Listening ~30-32/40 · Reading ~30-32/40 (Academic)
Band 6 conversion (approx.)	Listening ~23-26/40 · Reading ~23-26/40 (Academic)

Sources: IDP IELTS India fee schedule (April 2026), ielts.org test format; raw-score-to-band ranges are approximations that vary by paper.

Writing / Speaking criteria	Weight
Task Achievement (T1) / Task Response (T2) — or Fluency and Coherence in Speaking	25%
Coherence and Cohesion	25%
Lexical Resource	25%
Grammatical Range and Accuracy — or Pronunciation in Speaking	25%

Source: public band descriptors, ielts.org.

SECTION 48

Appendix B: The Weekly Review Template

Print or redraw this table and fill it every Sunday evening during your preparation. Ten honest minutes a week is the mechanism that turns a plan into a score.

Question to yourself	This week's honest answer
Focused study hours logged (target: 10-14)	
Listening passages done — errors classified in the log?	
Reading passages done — which question type lost marks?	

Question to yourself	This week's honest answer
Essays written — and reviewed (not just written)?	
Speaking recordings made — played back?	
Mock or timed set completed under exam conditions?	
The one question type to drill next week	
The one thing that went right (write it down anyway)	

Fill it Sunday evening; act on it Monday morning.

A final word. The test in front of you is fair, standardised and coachable — thousands of candidates with ordinary school English walk out every month with the bands they needed, not because they were lucky, but because they understood the machine, drilled their weak question types, and arrived on time with the right passport. Everything in this handbook is publicly available knowledge, gathered and verified so you do not spend your preparation weeks hunting it. The score you add from here is entirely your own. Good luck — and may your overview be clear and your position be early.